

May 12, 2026

Agent Ecosystem Working Group 2: Agent Adoption and Operations - MACH Alliance

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Attachments  Agent Ecosystem Working Group 2: Agent Adoption and Operations - ...

Summary

Working group participants established goals for defining enterprise agent adoption frameworks and organizational change strategies.

Group Charter and Mission

The initiative aims to help businesses distinguish between genuine utility and hype regarding agents. The primary mandate focuses on defining necessary organizational and operational changes for successful adoption.

Addressing Adoption Barriers

Participants identified a lack of executive understanding regarding probabilistic systems as a major barrier. The group plans to target early

adopters with resources that illustrate tangible value.

Defining Initial Deliverables

The group decided to create an enterprise agent adoption framework. This deliverable will provide a spectrum of relatable use cases to guide organizations through the transition.

Next steps

- ☐ [The group] Update GitHub: Stress test markdown in the GitHub contribution. Add names to the README file to show progress.
- ☐ [Rebecca Veldon] Create Slack: Set up a Slack channel for the working group. Establish asynchronous communication outside bi-weekly meetings.
- ☐ [The group] Populate Tracker: Add ideas for research topics or deliverables into the GitHub project issue tracker over the next couple of weeks.
- ☐ [The group] Update GitHub: Add name to the Readme file for contribution minimum.
- ☐ [The group] Define Use Cases: Determine necessary items for the early adopted group. Align proposed use cases towards MAC Alliance membership commonalities.
- ☐ [The group] Review Materials: Read through existing thoughts and materials put together.
- ☐ [Dylan Valade] Setup Slack: Activate and prepare the Slack channel for asynchronous work.

Details

- **Introductions and Setting the Agenda:** The meeting began with general greetings and weather discussion, including Andrew Kumar's drive from Toronto to Austin. Rebecca Veldon then outlined the day's agenda, which included introductions, a review of the working group charter, discussion on prioritizing deliverables, and

closing with next steps. They then started the round of introductions, where participants shared their roles, backgrounds, and specific expertise.

- **Speaker Introductions: Administration and Program Lead:** Rebecca Veldon, representing the Mach Alliance, positioned herself as the administrator ensuring smooth background operations. Everett Zufelt, who works at Orium, introduced themselves as the program lead for the agent ecosystem program at the Mach Alliance, clarifying that their role is to ensure the working groups have the necessary support and that their efforts align with broader initiatives.
- **Speaker Introductions: Education and Consulting:** Dylan Valade shared their history as an ambassador and former education chairman for the alliance, noting previous work on an architect certificate and learning modules. They mentioned their current involvement is their second time with the AI work at Mach, having previously participated in a cohort that provided valuable insights. Dylan Valade's current professional focus is consulting private equity-owned companies on leveling up their data for Business Intelligence (BI) and AI model development.
- **Speaker Introductions: Co-Chair and AI Doctrine:** Andrew Kumar, who is co-chairing the group with Dylan Valade, shared their extensive background working at several prominent companies in the Mach Alliance ecosystem, including Telus, Publicis Sapient, Contentful, and Uniform, and is currently at Bloom Reach. Their current professional focus is on AI doctrine and governance, with a bias toward building an AI layer at Bloom Reach using Mach principles like MCP APIs and web hooks.
- **Speaker Introductions: Delivery Practice and SI Expertise:** Jennifer Wright introduced themselves as the leader of the delivery practice at Orium, a systems integrator that works closely with Everett Zufelt. Their focus is on helping clients with the change management aspects of digital transformation, which now includes agentic adoption and operations. They view the working group's topic as having two sides: navigating change internally while also helping clients manage the transition.
- **Speaker Introductions: AI/Agentic Practice and Recruitment:** Ryan Lunka, the head of the AI and agentic practice at Aries (a systems integrator and Mach Alliance member), shared that their role involves leading all service initiatives related to AI and internal AI transformation. Mike Sandoz, representing the Mach Alliance, is focused on recruitment, specifically bringing in new members and collaborators for the agent ecosystem.

- **Speaker Introductions: Unified Commerce and Engineering:** Sezin Cagil, who oversees unified commerce at Dr. Martins, noted that their team is a large hands-on engineering community, making AI coding a top priority. They expressed concern about the business introducing AI tools without proper guardrails. Sezin Cagil previously worked with Dylan Valade on the first cohort and saw this as an interesting opportunity.
- **Working Group Focus and Charter Review:** Everett Zufelt explained the initiative's goal within the Mach Alliance is to help people distinguish between genuine utility and hype regarding agents. The other existing working group focuses on enterprise architecture for scaling agents. This group's specific mandate is addressing the "magic wand question"—if a business had all the agents they needed, what organizational and operational changes would be necessary for successful adoption and effective operation.
- **Identifying Adoption Barriers: Executive Understanding:** Ryan Lunka highlighted a major adoption barrier: the lack of fundamental understanding of agentic systems, particularly at the executive level. This includes difficulty understanding probabilistic systems versus traditional deterministic feature scoping, which necessitates a "rewiring" of executive thinking regarding budget approvals and requirements. Everett Zufelt agreed, noting the need to articulate what has changed in the world of AI that executives, who are familiar with the term, might not fully grasp the implication of.
- **Audience Targeting: Early Adopters and Change Agents:** The group discussed the target audience for their work, with Jennifer Wright suggesting they need to help people experience the "once you see it, you can't unsee it" moment. Dylan Valade suggested targeting the "change agents," or "rebels," within organizations—the people comfortable with uncertainty who need material to safely deploy agentic workflows. Everett Zufelt agreed the target should be "early adopters," not the innovators or the early majority, as this group needs just enough story and evidence to move forward.
- **Prioritizing Deliverables: The Cold Start Problem:** The conversation shifted to prioritizing deliverables, with Dylan Valade emphasizing that all work will be open and built on GitHub, potentially in formats like Markdown to serve as easy inputs for other agents. Jennifer Wright proposed creating a "getting started guide" or something similar to help people overcome the "I don't know where to start" problem. Andrew Kumar agreed that the "cold start problem" is very real, occurring frequently amid high vendor demand.

- **Addressing Executive Mindset and Organizational Culture:** Mike Sandoz asked Ryan Lunka what has successfully engaged executives, leading Ryan Lunka to suggest meeting them where they are, such as by discussing agentic coding, where there is already momentum. Everett Zufelt stressed that the "unseeable moment" is unique to each person's role. Sezin Cagil suggested looking at common patterns across different organizational units (orcs) to avoid thousands of combinations. Ryan Lunka then shared that a list of examples or case studies across different job functions would be helpful to illustrate how to cross the "chasm" from old ways of thinking.
- **Framework for Automation and Value Classification:** Dylan Valade explained a current approach that involves grounding people in four classifications of AI solutions, starting from simple co-pilot use to custom model building. This approach includes interviewing and flowchart mapping business processes across departments to quantify the monetary value of automation. This process helps distinguish between data problems and AI problems, leading to a quick win and making it "pretty obvious to all of them at a leadership level what cake they want to eat".
- **Next Steps for the Working Group:** Everett Zufelt outlined three next steps, mirroring the other working group: Rebecca Veldon will set up a Slack channel for asynchronous communication. The group needs to put together a draft of a first artifact, perhaps relating to explaining the current shift in the world, and everyone should start adding topic ideas and deliverables to the GitHub project issue tracker. Jennifer Wright suggested the first artifact should be gathering real-life examples across different categories to provide a blueprint.
- **Focusing the First Deliverable: Adoption Framework:** Ryan Lunka cautioned against only including "big ones" in the list of examples, suggesting they need a spectrum of examples along the maturity curve, including smaller, relatable use cases. Ryan Lunka then proposed that the deliverable should be grounded in the enterprise agent adoption framework, which is the first proposed artifact, as it would be more tangible than a loose collection of content.
- **Challenges of Transformation and Iterative Processes:** The group discussed the difficulty of discussing the "transformation" required for agents at scale without scaring people. Ryan Lunka emphasized that successful adoption requires an iterative, lean-oriented approach because the territory is "probabilistic" and "uncharted," similar to the internet in 1999. This framework must lay out why uncomfortable iterative exploration is necessary for success.

- **Identifying Business Value and Next Meeting:** Mike Sandoz questioned whether enough data exists to create a proven, simplified framework, noting that many companies are still struggling. Dylan Valade suggested focusing on commerce, the Mach Alliance's sweet spot, and involving the CFO to quantify the financial contribution of revenue and cost. The core value is stopping businesses from "leaving money on the table". The next meeting is scheduled for the 26th of May.
- **Next Steps and GitHub Contribution:** Dylan Valade requested that, for the next meeting, all participants contribute to the GitHub repository by at least adding their name to the readme. They suggested each member propose what they believe is necessary for the early adopted group, focusing on use cases common to the MAC alliance membership, as this group is the primary target audience.
- **MAC Alliance Focus and Required Tasks:** The group agreed to focus on the MAC alliance as the primary area of focus since efforts to engage other executives and C-suites have not been successful. Additional tasks include reading through the existing materials and establishing a Slack channel for asynchronous communication, which is expected to facilitate progress.
- **Meeting Conclusion and Positive Outlook:** The conversation was viewed as a good start to the week, and participants agreed that the implementation of asynchronous communication via Slack will simplify the flow of ideas. Everett Zufelt confirmed there were no remaining items for discussion .

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